

HOW YOUR BABY DEVELOPS

Being aware of your baby's pattern of development in these early months can also help you to target play to enhance her development, and make sure that you aren't frustrating her with activities beyond her capabilities.



Physical skills

Your baby will need some time to learn control of her limbs. Her movements are uncoordinated in the early weeks; she is slowly unfurling and stretching her limbs after being curled up in your uterus. As her muscles strengthen, however, you can provide opportunities for her to practice moving her limbs and body.

» **Place your baby on her back** to allow her to get used to moving her limbs around, waving her arms, and kicking her legs. This gentle exercise will develop and strengthen her muscles.

» **Join your little one on the floor** and talk to her about what she is doing, or put her under a play gym so she can swoosh and bat at the dangling objects.

» **Put your baby on her tummy**, when she is a little stronger. As your baby gets older, she is likely to become increasingly excited and to kick and wave enthusiastically. A few moments of "tummy time" each day will help to strengthen her back and neck muscles, and will set her on the path to rolling and crawling.

» **Give your baby an incentive to reach out** when her strength and coordination grow. Place your baby on her tummy on the floor with a colorful toy just in front of her so she can practice reaching out. Always supervise tummy time when your baby is very young, and don't leave her on her tummy if she becomes frustrated.



Social and cognitive skills

Reading, singing, and talking to your baby all help develop her language skills. Your first "conversations"—responding to your baby's coos and gurgles with ones of your own—enable her to watch the shapes your mouth makes, learn about sounds, and copy the noises you make. These interactions also teach important social skills: how conversations involve taking turns and listening.



Your baby's senses

Stimulating your baby's senses is incredibly important in these early months. Your baby learns about the world around her through touch, and also derives comfort from cuddling, caresses, and skin-to-skin contact. Although she can focus her eyes only a short distance at birth, she will soon be taking in everything she sees.

» **Provide a feast for your baby's eyes** with bold patterns, mirrors, and bright objects.

» **Cloth books** with different textures help teach concepts such as smooth and bumpy, soft and hard, furry and crinkly.

» **Talk about and identify textures** and point out contrasts in everyday objects.

» **Comment on different noises** that you can hear inside the house or outside, and talk about the aromas in the kitchen.



Outdoor Exploration

Day trips out with your baby can keep you both feeling fresh. A walk to the store, a longer trip to the park, or just some time in the yard all provide a change of environment and new stimulation for your baby. Talk to her about the sights and sounds outside: look at the leaves blowing in the breeze, at the pattern of clouds or shadows on the ground, and at the buses, trains, and planes passing by.



WHEN YOUR BABY HAS HAD ENOUGH



Rest time Even low-key family visits can feel intense for a baby, especially if she's passed around.

Every day your baby is absorbing and enjoying new sights, sounds, and information, but she also tires easily. If she doesn't have an opportunity for some downtime, she can feel overwhelmed by too many new noises, activities, and sensations.

Try to plan your baby's day so that there are times when activities are downscaled, and be alert to signs that your baby has had enough. Symptoms of overstimulation and fatigue include:

- » Becoming fussy and cranky.
- » Turning her head away from you and from toys and activities.
- » Appearing withdrawn.

If your young baby has been awake for about two hours, she probably needs to be put down for a nap. Or she may just benefit from some quiet time in her crib, or being cradled in your arms.